



## TOLL OF HATE

**OCTOBER 1984:** Bajrang Dal was created at Ayodhya as an armed wing of the VHP to provide security cover to the Ayodhya-Lucknow Ram-Janki Rath Yatra led by Vinay Katiyar on October 7.

**1984-92:** Played a key role in the Ram Shila Yatras across the country, which led to communal carnage in Bhagalpur in 1989, and Shila Poojan as a build-up to the demolition of Babri Masjid.

**1990:** It formed a security ring to L.K. Advani's Somnath-Ayodhya Ramrath Yatra. Forced everyone to chant 'Jai Shree Ram' throughout the route. Advani described it as the biggest mass mobilisation since Independence.

**DEC 6, 1992:** Bajrang Dal members played a leading role in the demolition of the Babri structure.

was, according to police reports, revealed by the accused in the Nanded blast during their narco-analysis and brain-mapping tests.

Then on August 24 this year, a bomb exploded while being manufactured in a private hostel in Kanpur, killing two persons—Piyush Mishra, 25 and Bhupinder Singh, 32. Police later found that Singh was formerly the Bajrang Dal's city chief. Meanwhile, controversy surrounding the organisation got a new twist when a senior VHP leader and former BJP MP Ram Vilas Vedanti claimed he had received threats from SIMI and Al-Qaida terrorists. Police traced the calls to two youth, including Bajrang Dal's Katra city chief Ramesh Tiwari. It turned out they had been asked to make the calls so that Vedanti's security could be upgraded at par with Praveen Togadia and Ashok Singhal.

However, the bombing incidents forced the Union Home Ministry to take a hard look at the organisation. While Bajrang Dal maintains that those involved in bomb-making had nothing to do with the organisation, Sharma admitted that some of the people who died in the process might have been members in the distant past. "How could Bajrang Dal be blamed for it?" he asks. They also point to extreme provocation in the case of the carnage in Orissa's Kandhamal district—the killing of 84-year-old VHP ideologue Swami Lakshmananda Saraswati. The violence in Karnataka was sparked by a booklet written by a neo-convert Lakshminarayan which had several derogatory references to

Hindu gods and goddesses. Bajrang Dal leaders also claim that most of the 16 prayer halls attacked in Karnataka were unauthorised and "caused anguish among local people", an euphemism for Hindu sentiments.

Whatever the provocation, the organisation's profile has assumed dangerous proportions. Former Uttar Pradesh chief minister Mulayam Singh Yadav, said: "If SIMI could be banned then why can't Bajrang Dal be outlawed?" Congress leader Digvijay Singh too concurs, "It is part of the same coin just like SIMI and should be banned." The anti-Christian violence also prompted CPIM, CPI, CPI(M), and Ram Vilas Paswan of the Lok Janashakti Party to demand a ban on Bajrang Dal and the VHP. The demand has provoked a sharp response from the leadership. "How dare anyone equate us with SIMI? We are *rashtravaadi* (nationalists) and they are anti-national terrorists. The Government should put these leaders under narco-tests to establish their links with terrorist outfits like SIMI and Indian Mujahideen," says Sharma angrily.

**A**ccording to the estimates by the All India Catholic Union, 37 Christians have been killed, including two Protestant pastors in Orissa. More than 4,000 homes belonging to Christians have been burned and at least 50,000 Christians were forced to flee. Priests and lay-converted Christians were attacked and often forced to re-convert to Hinduism. This mayhem has spread down south as well when Bangalore churches were attacked, followed by Kerala, where two of the oldest churches in India were vandalised. Cardinal Oswald Gracias, the archbishop of Mumbai, called the current campaign against Christians by Hindu extremists "inexplicable," a "disgrace" and "madness" while in Bangalore Archbishop Bernard Moras told Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa that the Christian community is "very hurt" because of attacks on churches and "is ready to shed blood to protect the faith".

The signs are ominous. On the night of September 29, fresh violence erupted in G. Udaygiri and Tikabali areas, claiming the life of a woman and injuring seven others, three critically. It was preceded by blasts at three relief camps shaking the peace process and creating fear among the Christians. In fact, two other blasts on the same night in Malegaon in Maharashtra and Modasa in Gujarat were in Muslim-dominated areas, raising fears that the Bajrang Dal may have decided on a new and dangerous strategy, to retaliate and take revenge against the community—an act that can only increase the chances of a communal flare-up, something that, ironically, can only play into the hands of the jihadis. ■



VINAY KATIYAR,  
BJP LEADER

**"the Centre  
denies ban the  
organisation,  
it will be  
forced to lick  
the dust."**